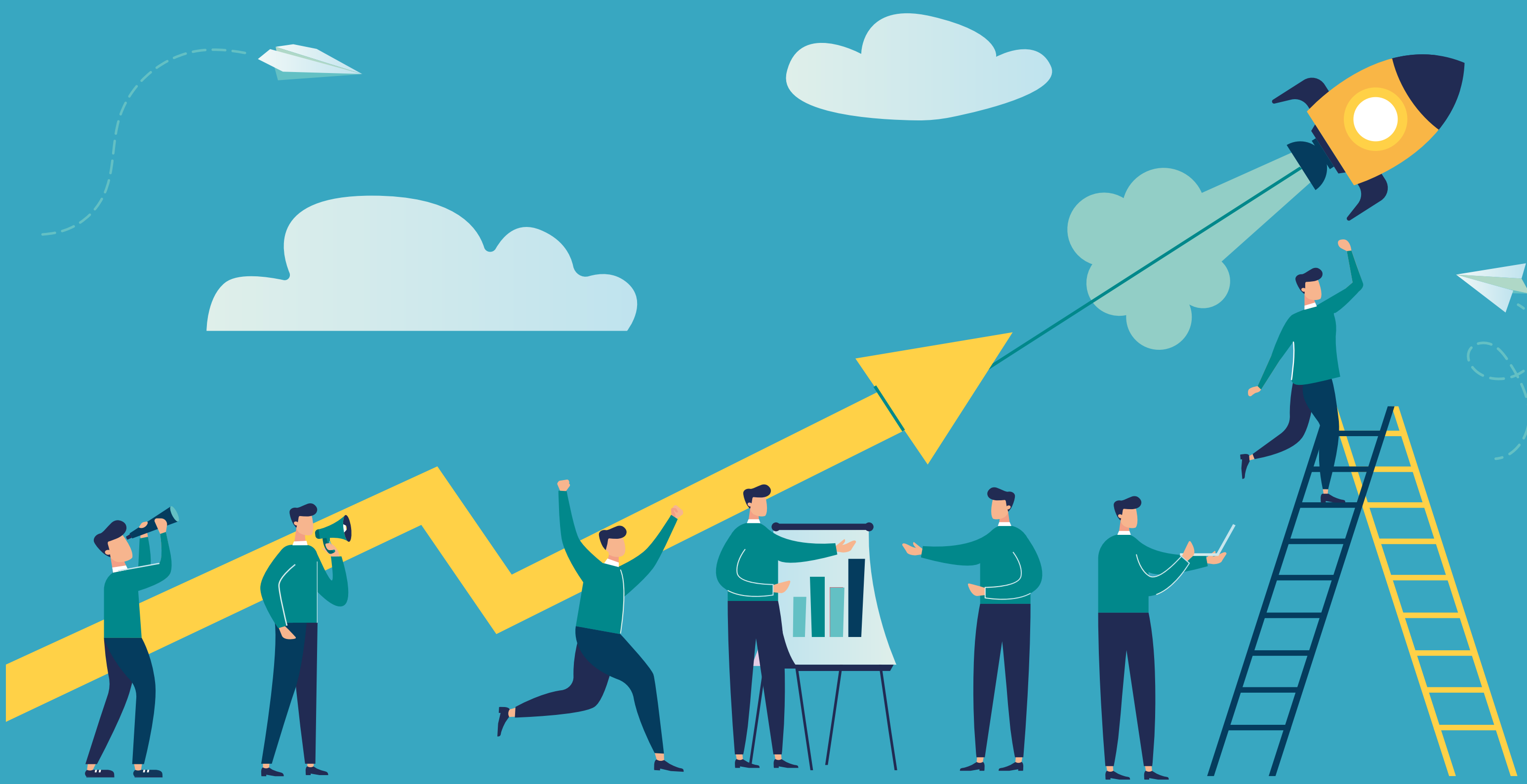

Entrepreneur INSIGHTS

A Beginner's Guide to Starting Your Own Business

What You Need to Know to Get Started

DELL Technologies

Introduction

Attempting to start your own business can be daunting. There's a seeming never-ending laundry list of tasks to complete and you don't know what to do first. This is where we come in! With over 40 years of experience, we know exactly what it takes to get a business up and running—and the strategies that work to battle through the long hours and intense stress founders face day in and day out.

We've put together this collection of proven tips and tactics to allow you to approach the startup process with confidence. You'll discover how to vet profitable business ideas, find funding, start a business with as little as $1,000, and so much more.

We hope this booklet inspires and helps you make the leap. If you want to dive deeper into the startup process, visit us at: entrepreneur.com/starting-a-business.

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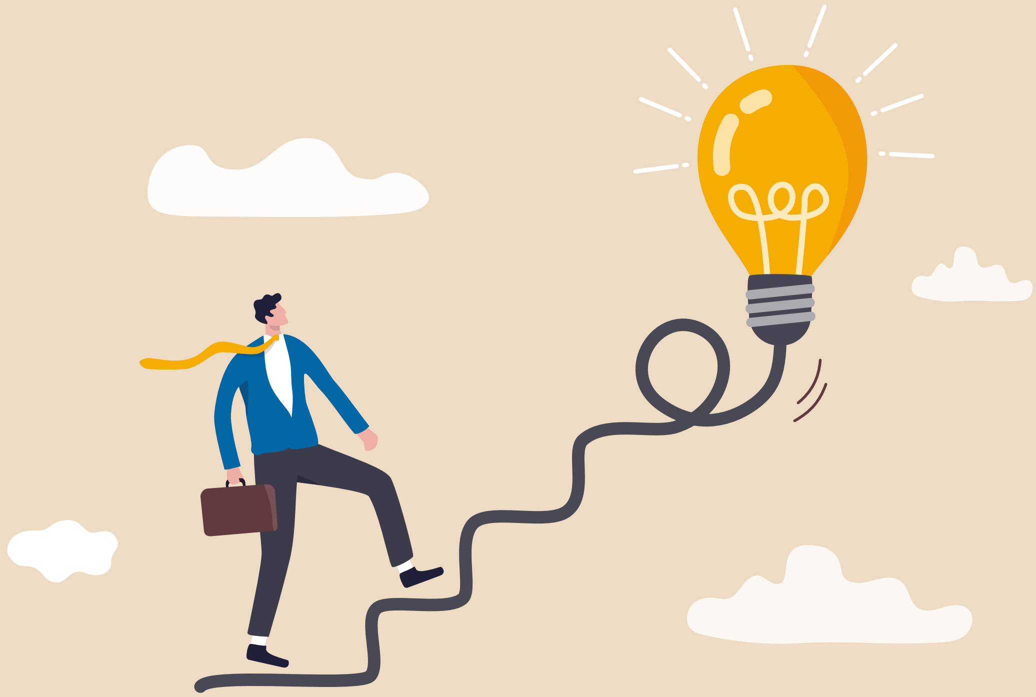


3 Steps to Creating a Profitable Business Idea

Competition is mounting, so don't waste time and money solving non-existent problems.

by **Alexander Zheltov**, *CEO of Educate Online*

According to the Bureau of Labor Statistics, 20% of startups are closed in the first year, and half of them within the first five years. **CBInsights** reports 35% of startups fail because of a lack of market demand, among others failure reasons — cash flow problems, getting outcompeted, a flawed **business** model and legal challenges.

I wasn't passionate about wasting time and money solving non-existent problems, so before launching my business, I committed to doing great analytic work with my team. Here are three tips I've gained from my experience of **starting a business** that will help you be successful both short and long term.

1. Stop romanticizing about the business idea

Loving what you do and doing what you love sounds romantic and inspiring, but not in business reality. First of all, you need to assess whether there's enough market demand for your passion to be profitable. For instance, you like good coffee and even understand its varieties. Perhaps you have even taken barista courses or, moreover, won championships. But here's the bad luck: In your city, there are coffee shops on every corner and the competition is very high. Should you open coffee shop #101 on one street and hope that people will come to you? If you don't mind the time, money and effort, then you can give it a try. But it's much better to ask yourself a few questions before starting a business:

- What is the real reason you want to start a business?
- What are your personal and business goals?
- Who is your customer?
- What problems does your customer have, and how can your business resolve them?
- What do your competitors propose, and how will you differ from them?
- Which resources do you need for launching a business?

2. Don't underestimate your competitors

You need to look at the market soberly and analyze your competitors. This is especially important if you are going to attract investments. After all, one of the critical questions that a potential investor will ask is your competitive advantage.

Here's a three-step system you can use to analyze the market :

1. Primary research: Instead of fantasizing about what the consumer wants, you can ask them directly. Use questionnaires, research and interviews for this. If you already have customers, you can use statistics from Google Analytics, **YouTube**, social media, email-services reports and other platforms to understand customers' preferences and behavior.
2. Secondary research: Systematize the information received and study it in detail. Does this match your understanding of the market? How can your product solve customer requests?
3. SWOT analysis: A SWOT analysis is a reliable way to study the strengths, weaknesses, opportunities and threats of an idea. From the analysis, you can decide whether the market needs a product and whether you'll get the profit you expect. You can easily find templates for this system on the internet and conduct an analysis.

As the result of this research, you'll find the answers to these questions:

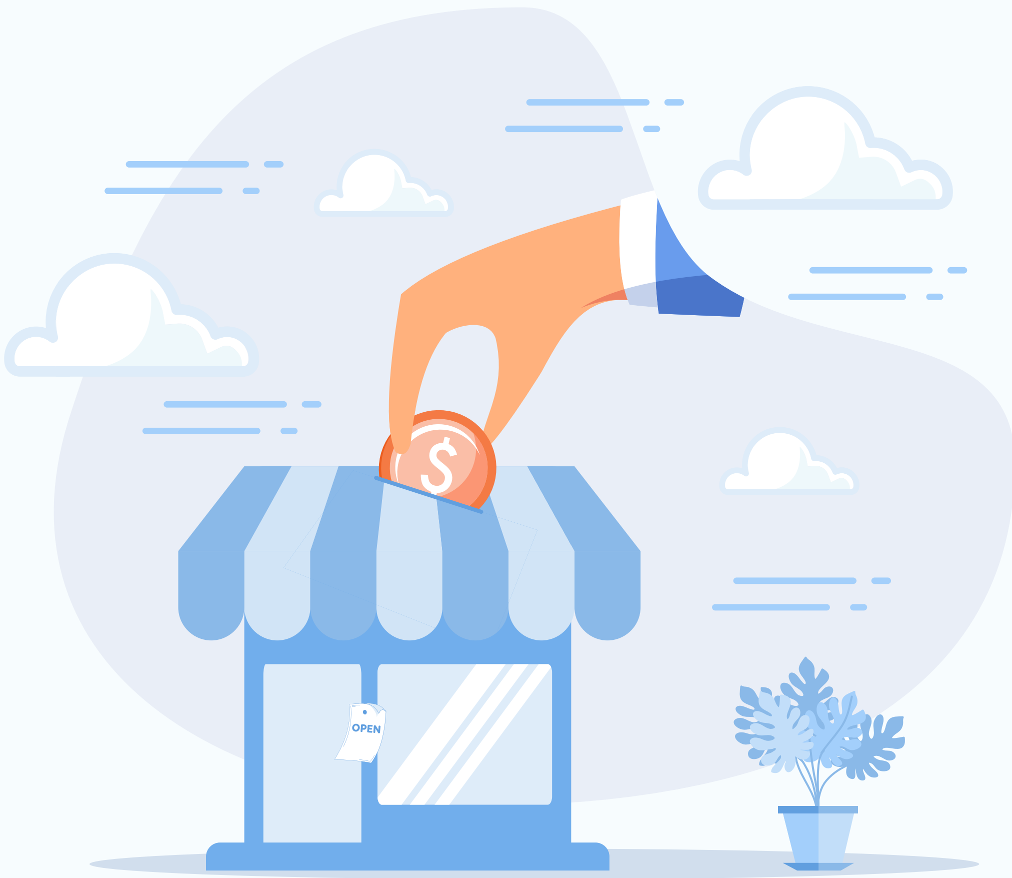
- Who are your customers, and what are their sales, valuations and limitations?
- Who are your competitors, and what do your potential customers like/dislike in their products?
- What should you propose to the market to be more successful?
- What kind of unique offer can you provide?

Test your hypothesis

Once you've researched the market and know what the consumer wants, you need to ensure that your product meets their demand. Moreover, this should be done as cheaply as possible, in the form of an MVP (**Minimum Viable Product**). Long story short, an MVP provides an opportunity to develop a new product for less money and collect reviews from potential customers.

Another instrument to validate your assumptions about future business is A/B Testing. You can use this method to check what kind of website version or design customers like better. For example, you can create two versions of the same offer's landing page, with the same price and text but different designs or block layouts. Then you analyze which version consumers spent the most time on and which got you more quality leads.

Only after these three steps should you start looking for investments and teams. This way, you can be sure that money and effort will not be wasted, and your startup will not become a mere failure statistic.



5 Ways to Fund Your Startup as a Solopreneur

Funding your small business can be nerve-racking. Use these five steps to fund your startup without feeling overwhelmed.

by **Christina-Lauren Pollack**, *Entrepreneur, Executive, Influencer & Business Branding Coach*

While there are several different ways to fund your new business, many options are either expensive, require collateral (such as personal assets), or involve the participation and expectations of other people (as in the case of friends and family loans, funding from angel investors or **venture capital** financing). If you prefer to self-fund your business ventures, here are five smart ways to fund your startup as a solopreneur.

Open a savings account

A great way to begin your business is to open a **savings account**. We have all heard the famous adage that "cash is king." If you've already set aside funds to get your business going, use your savings account as a central location for all the money intended to start your operation.

Depending on your type of business, you'll need to set aside funding for legal expenses (such as trademark filings), building your online presence and any goods costs. You should always have separate savings account for personal expenses that may arise. Never use up all of your savings just to start a business.

Open a credit card

A second way to fund your business is with **credit cards**. If you have to use a credit card to fund your business, apply for a credit card that offers 12-18 months of 0% APR interest, a high credit limit ($25,000 or more), and at least 2% cash-back rewards. This will enable you to quickly start investing in your startup while having at least a year to build up your sales revenue and profits. But, you'll want to make sure that before the interest rate kicks in (after 12-18 months), you're able to pay off your balance in full.

Credit cards can quickly lead to high-cost debt and high-interest rates without payment discipline. Be mindful of this as you evaluate this option for funding your company.

Open a personal loan

A third way to **finance** your startup as a solopreneur is to open a **personal loan** with a bank. Because most traditional banks require collateral (personal property) to secure a loan and generally only offer short-term loans that require payback within a couple of years, a smarter option is to apply for a personal loan with an online bank that offers competitive rates, such as **SoFi**.

As an example, if you have good credit (750+ credit score), you could potentially be granted a $25,000 non-collateralized personal loan with a 5-year term, 12% annual interest rate and a monthly payment of around $600. In addition to giving you an extended period to pay off the loan and build up a positive cash flow in your business, it also helps to boost your credit score. Another added benefit of this option is that you can apply to refinance a loan after three months of payments, which can potentially lower your monthly payment and interest rate.

Utilize "buy now, pay later" programs

Another route to funding your new business is to outsource the payment of your sales. If you are running an online business, tools like **Klarna** or **Afterpay** pay your company for purchases made by your customers, while allowing your customers to pay in easy installments at later times. These types of "buy now, pay later" systems are especially helpful to your customers if your site has higher-priced products (such as high-ticket courses, luxury goods, or home furnishings) and it encourages them to place orders, even if they want to pay over time. These programs allow your business to have the money immediately, without extending credit to customers (which is a risk for any business).

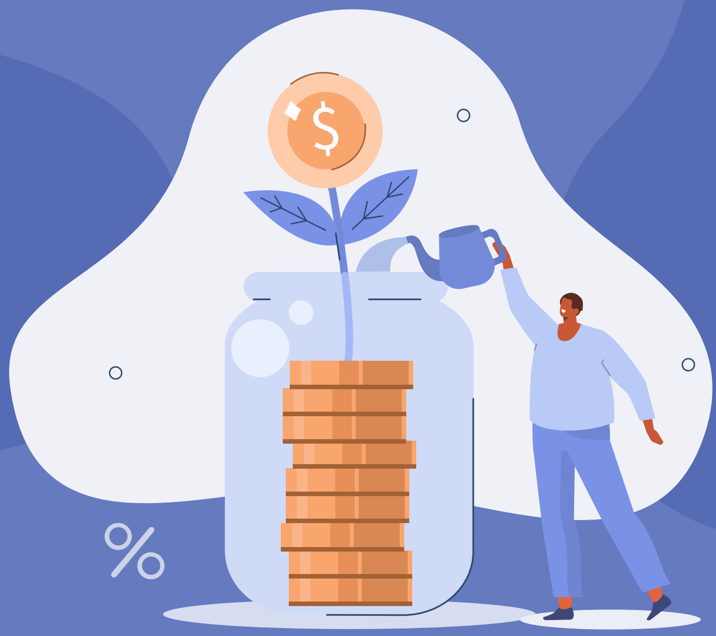
Launch a Kickstarter

And finally, the fifth way to inject cash into your new business is to launch a **Kickstarter campaign**. This crowdfunding site enables business owners to raise funds from potential customers and people they know. It's also a great way to boost online visibility, increase brand awareness and test the viability of a business idea with real feedback.

The best way to get people to invest in your business via Kickstarter is to leverage your social media channels to spread the word about your campaign. It also helps to build a sense of community and engagement around your brand, leading to customer loyalty.

Another thing to keep in mind when evaluating your budget for your startup is that you can save thousands of dollars each month by not hiring expensive agencies. Many public relations firms charge at least $5,000 per month to send out just one press release, and several Facebook advertising agencies charge a minimum of $10,000 per month to run ads for your business. Not to mention they cannot guarantee publicity or sales conversions.

As you can see, there are a variety of ways to finance your new startup as a solopreneur without having to take on investors or partners. Depending on your goals and where you're starting, each of these financing options has its pros and cons. Do your research and evaluate funding routes as you plan your business launch.



How to Start a Business with Only $1,000

$1,000 can take you far if you know how to spend it!

by **Patrick Frank**, *COO of PatientPartner*

When you think about starting a company, the first two questions that come to mind are: "How much is this going to cost, and how am I going to get that kind of capital?"

The dynamics of **funding a business** have dramatically changed over time. Where once you were resigned to bank loans and savings, there are now many options to choose from to help get your business off the ground.

However, let's take a step back. You should ask: "What is the minimal amount of capital I need to get this off the ground?" For those first few steps, $1,000 can get you moving quickly and far along. It is all about what I call "resource capital," a mixture of your time, money and effort.

The price does not always equal the value

As a disclaimer: I am guilty of falling victim to thinking that I had to have the best of the best when starting our company. We always went for the most expensive external partners for operational needs. A hefty price tag could at least give us confidence that we'd be getting exactly what we paid for, right? We found that just because a company spends a lot of time and money on its reputation, it does not mean that it will deliver. We had to learn that going the less expensive route was not always bad.

Building your business

Building a business is like building a house. You have to dream it up, create a blueprint and get all the necessary permits from the city. From there comes all the fun stuff, like designing, building and scaling.

Starting off the same way, we have to think about our business and our $1,000 in very similar steps:

The Permits

- Business Filings: ($50 - $150 depending on location)

Every state has a site or process for **starting a business** which can typically be found on the Secretary of State's website. California, for example, allows you to choose your name, pay your fee, obtain your EIN, and then your business is official. Depending on the corporate structure, this can be more complex. Still, many people make the mistake of using online services to file businesses when, in reality, it is simpler than many are led to believe.

The Blueprints

- Your Website or Landing Page: (Free - $150/month)

There are a variety of platforms you can choose for this. I recommend not spending a lot of time building out an entire site. Instead, build a simple landing page that provides an exciting outline of your business. Think of this as the digital billboard you can use when explaining what you are building to others.

Don't hire some expensive web designer to build it your first go around. There is a 100% chance it is going to change.

- Website domain & Email: ($12 - $60)

Always buy the domain if you can, or an offshoot of it (e.g., ".co" or ".io." No one will take a business seriously if it does not have a proper domain name. This is simple to do at places like **GoDaddy** and Google Domains.

Next, create your new email address with your new domain name — your first name and company name will do. If you want a more general support email, use "hello@" or "info@" instead. In many cases, website platforms have packages where the domain and the email are included. Take advantage of these cost savings out of the gate.

The Designs

Your early **branding** is crucial in getting people to take you seriously. To successfully build a brand, your business has to look the part.

Creative (Logo, Branding): ($100 - $350)

If you are not creative and need help with things like logos and branding, there are resources such as 99Designs, Fiverr and even **Etsy**, where you can hire brand specialists to help you. Being consistent with how you present your brand out of the gate is incredibly important and helps align yourself with the brand and its mission, and it is an exciting and fun win you can celebrate right off the bat.

Laying the foundation

- SAAS Tools: (Free - $100)

Now that you are ready to build your "house," it is time to pick your tools. There are thousands of options for SAAS products, depending on what you are doing. The key thing to remember here is only to utilize what you need and always choose the free trial first. These companies are built to hook you for free and prepare you to pay as you scale. If you need to pay for their service, I recommend spending a maximum of $100 on these.

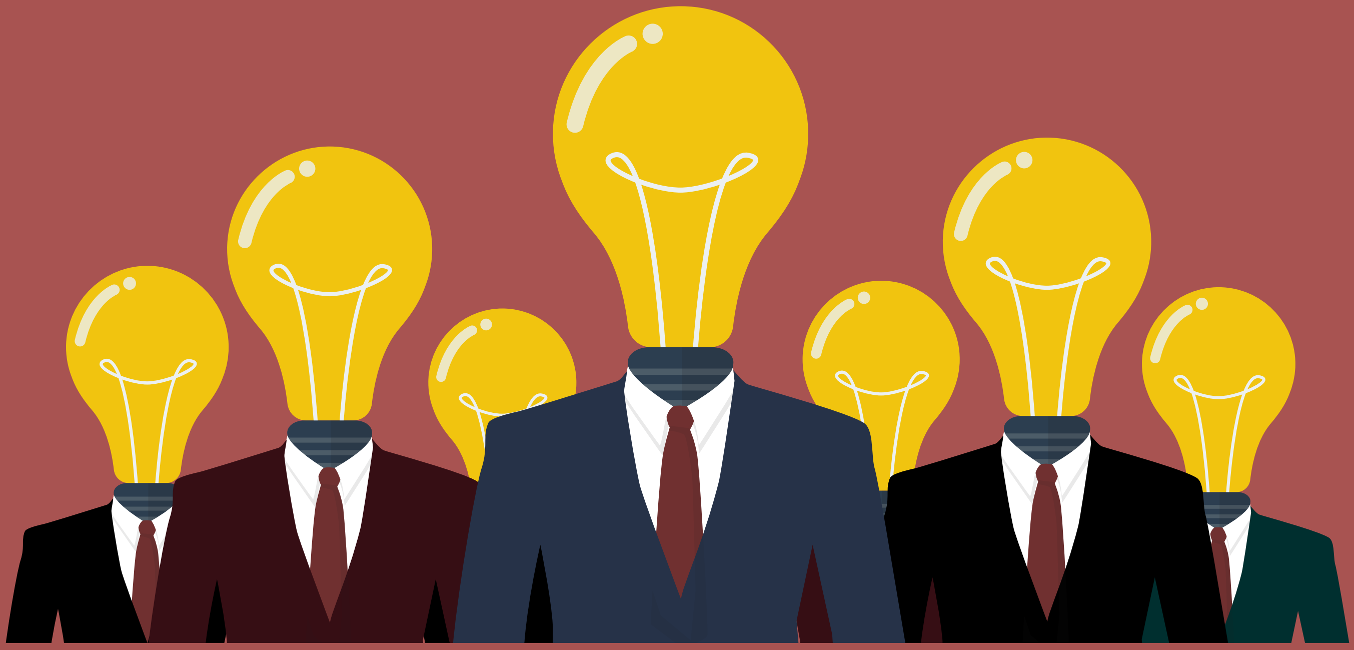
Finding your contractor

- Virtual Assistant: ($300-$500)

If you are starting alone or even with a partner, you will be shocked to find out what $10 per day can get you. When it comes to **virtual assistants**, this cash can get you just about anything you need. The goal is to ensure you get someone of quality who understands your work style and brand. This will not only result in you learning to delegate and build a team but will offload a minimum of four hours each day of work.

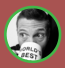
When starting a company, one of the most significant issues is the number of menial tasks that need to be done. Having someone to handle those is critical. If you need someone more project-based rather than part-time or full-time, I recommend looking to places like Fiverr instead of Upwork, which is typically meant for more seasoned, US-based contractors.

Back to that key figure, $1,000 is more than enough cash to lay the basic foundations. It's also enough money for your startup to at least appear like a legitimate company, which is half the battle.



7 Things No One Tells You About Starting a Business

Here are seven valuable tips for starting a business with confidence.



by **Aaron Vick**, *Web3 Advisor*

"You're crazy!" "Are you sure?" "That's going to be hard." These are all things entrepreneurs hear when they talk about **starting a business**. The critics aren't wrong; it is going to be hard, but that doesn't have to stop you from being successful in your business.

As long as you strategize, plan and read this article before starting a business, you'll be well on your way. Here are seven tips that no one tells you before you start your business:

1. It's still about who you know

When you start your own business, you may have done so for an array of reasons. One of them may be because you didn't have the right contacts to get a job where you wanted in the first place.

Unfortunately, opening up a business solo isn't void of other people. You'll need partners, potentially, and at least other business contacts to help you advertise. Don't delete your contacts, because you don't think you need them. Believe me, you do.

2. You'll want to quit

As passion-driven as you are, there are still times when you're starting your business that you'll feel like throwing in the towel. Even if you "do what you love," running your own business is hard.

Work can exhaust you, so make sure you're taking breaks. Even if they're mini-breaks between phone calls or meetings, giving yourself a little breathing time is essential. Contrary to what many believe, taking breaks doesn't cut into your productivity. It's quite the opposite. A well-timed and well-deserved break can re-energize you and help you get through the rest of your day faster.

3. It's non-stop

When you're starting your own business, there is always more work to do. When you can always be working, and there's no one to put restrictions on you, you'll find yourself working all the time.

Don't do that! **Set boundaries** for yourself and for your workday. Some days you'll have to work later or earlier than others. If you can, only schedule meetings or consultations within your personal work hours. If you have to work late one night, make sure you stick to your limit the next day.

Burnout is a big reason that businesses have a hard time getting off the ground or never launch at all. Don't let your hard work go to waste!

4. Everyone will have an opinion
If you have kids, you know that everyone has something to say about raising them. The same goes for when you're "raising" a business.

You might mention to a friend that you're having an issue with something to blow off some steam. Then, when you only needed to feel listened to, they go off with three ways to fix your problem.

They mean well, but you don't have to listen to them or take their advice. Seek advice with trusted **advisors and mentors** who have been in the trenches before you, so there's some wisdom in alternative opinions.

5. You'll have to ask for money
Whether you thought you had enough capital or you underestimated the loan you need, you'll have to ask for more. This is true for a reasonable percentage of startups.

Asking for money is hard, especially if you're asking for more from the same person/entity. Don't feel guilty about it — though it may seem like that's all your brain wants to do. Come up with a plan for how you'll use the money and how you'll pay it back.

If you're borrowing from the same person again, show them that you have a plan for how you'll use their money so that you don't run out again. Being able to show how you will spend the money shows you have spent time defining projections, runways, timelines and go-to-market strategies is key to backing up your confidence in the company.

6. You can't double dip for customers
A lot of people make the mistake of thinking their friends and family will be their first clients. While that's true for maybe 20% of your personal network, that doesn't mean you can count on them to get your business off the ground.

You have to **invest in marketing**, both digital and traditional. Where can you go and promote your business to interested customers? Too many small business owners spend so much on startup costs, they forget to advertise.

That's the kiss of death for a new business. Using at least 10% of your budget for marketing will ensure you don't doom yourself. You can always buy more decor as you make profits, but you can't buy back under-utilized time.

7. You'll need to reinvest
It's exciting when you make a profit for the first time as a business owner. You stressed all that time about being able to pay everyone, the rent, buy supplies, etc. — but making a profit shows a great step in operational achievement and synergy.

Of course, you may feel like spending your profit on a reward for yourself or something new and exciting for your shop. But stop and think: How can I **reinvest that profit** back into my business? Maybe buy some more ad space or add to your cost-per-click budget. You may have a need to hire a new employee or pay off a debt that has a high interest rate.

What I'm saying is, your profit should cover your expenses, then go straight back into your business to make a bigger profit next month or create operational efficiencies for scaling. Don't worry, once you do this for the first month, you can invest a little less the next month or create/update budgets.

With these tips in mind, some capital and the right business strategy, you're all set to start your business. It won't be a straight road to the top, and it's okay to have some roadblocks along the way. We all face them, even the unicorns.

The best thing to do when issues arise is to ask for advice from a network of mentors and advisors. Seek to learn more things unique to your niche, and ask your advisors the hard questions to help unlock the early mysteries of starting a business.

Here Are 4 Tips For Scaling Your Startup During a Downturn

Successful startups are product-led, customer-focused, scrappy and super-competitive. Nothing gets you there faster than building in a downturn. I've done it.

by **Jyoti Bansal**, *Founder of Harness, Traceable, AppDynamics and Unusual Ventures*

The message was written on a tombstone: "RIP Good Times."

I launched my first company during the Great Recession. AppDynamics had ten employees and a product implementation problem with Netflix, our second customer, when Sequoia Capital released its now famous RIP memo in October 2008. Many early-stage companies around us died off while funding disappeared. I watched as our runway dwindled to just a few months. I was building at a time of mourning.

Fast-forward to 2022, and here we are again — with grave warnings from investors. Call it a "startup recession" or a VC funding drought,

but **inflation** is up and the market is down. However, this doesn't have to signal demise for the next generation of entrepreneurs. Downturns force founders into fight-or-flight mode. Survivors can emerge even stronger.

AppDynamics thrived and went on to a $3.7 billion acquisition. That was not my only experience with building in a downturn. In July 2020, while the pandemic frightened off institutional and retail investors alike, I launched my cybersecurity company, Traceable.

Doom-and-gloom headlines exaggerate market changes, but history proves success is possible. With that in mind, here are four tips for startup survival:

1. Get ruthless about what customers want (and give it to them)

Over the last decade, easy funding has enabled **startups** to scale in the absence of revenue. In many cases, promising technologies haven't translated to products that people will actually pay for. With funding drying up, that luxury is gone.

And that's a good thing. Now, you're forced to focus obsessively on what will actually drive revenue and bring in customers. Peripheral concerns, bloated budgets and side projects fade as you fight to stay in the game.

At AppDynamics, that started with honing in on a very specific target customer that desperately needed our service. We went after companies, like Netflix, where application speeds were directly tied to revenue. Then we streamlined our feature set to focus on one problem: helping engineers troubleshoot the root cause of slow software.

This went hand in hand with fanatical attention to customer support. Nearly every day for two months, I drove 90 minutes from our office in San Francisco to Netflix headquarters in Los Gatos to observe our product in their environment and ensure it was delivering value. This focus enabled us to do something difficult back then: extend our runway.

2. There's still money on the table. Pick it up.

Frothy funding has disappeared, but if you need money, it's still out there — especially for early-stage companies. Series A valuations may have peaked in 2021, but they remain historically high. Investors have an enormous amount of dry powder sitting on the sidelines waiting to be invested.

Securing investment starts with showing metrics that matter. A growing customer base, strong retention and low burn rates will open the door to funding opportunities. Likewise, it's not helpful right now to obsess too much about your share price or valuation multiples. Valuations go up and down. What's important is to **raise the capital** you need to build your business. Startups able to stay in the game can recoup valuation in subsequent rounds.

There's a silver lining here, as well. As funding takes longer to secure, there's more time for due diligence. Startups can seek out value-add VCs who offer mentorship and industry expertise, not just easy money.

When it comes to how to spend that money, be strategic, not ruthless. Look at overhead, and **negotiate with vendors** who have incentive to bring costs down while everyone reduces spending. Reduce reliance on pricey contractors and agencies, and seek to bring expertise in-house. And then, turn your attention to the most important resource in a downturn: your team.

3. Don't push pause on key hires

Many startups impose hiring freezes during recessions or resort to drastic layoffs. But there's a fundamental paradox in play here: Without people, you can't grow.

At the same time, recessions offer a huge recruiting advantage as competitors get skittish or die off. Before Lehman Brothers went under in September 2008, AppDynamics was fighting to fill every role. But afterward, we had our pick of talent. Right now, hard-to-find developers are suddenly available. It's also easier to attract people from established companies whose stock options and RSUs are underwater.

With resources limited, prioritize hires who can come in and immediately move the needle. With a small team, I initially shouldered HR and accounting functions myself. Instead, we put every resource into engineering, sales and customer support — the crucial flywheel needed to generate and grow revenue.

4. Use adversity — and transparency — to rally your team

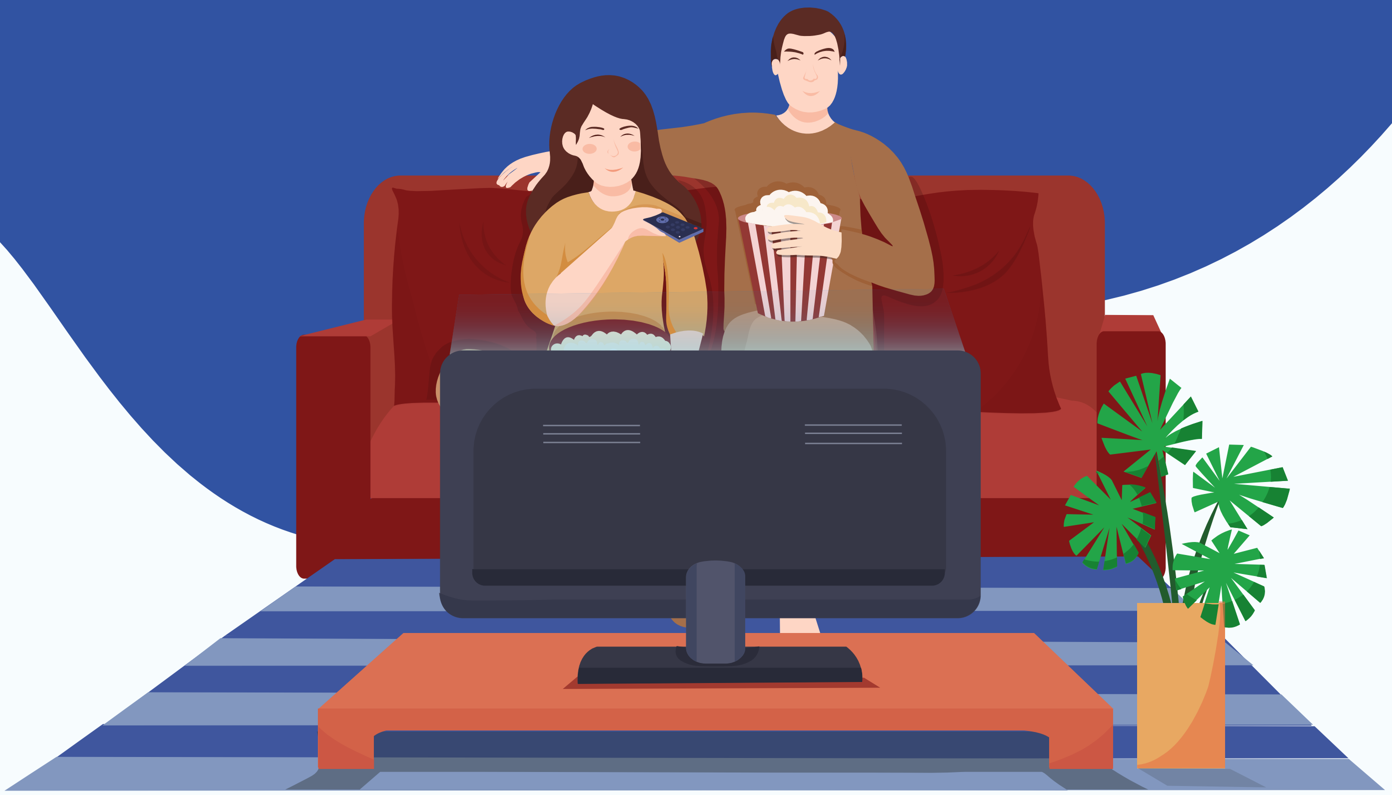
Now is not the time for secrets or platitudes. Your team can also see the news and knows what's happening in the market; tell them where the company stands.

I was crystal clear about the metrics needed to make it to our next funding round at AppDynamics. We needed 20-25 new customers to secure our Series B. Knowing that gave everyone a singular mission and a sense of urgency. This wasn't a hypothetical goal. It was a deadline that was fast approaching.

Frequent communication is also key. A week is too long to wait for updates when your runway is months, not years. Daily all-hands sync-ups at AppDynamics covered customer touchpoints, tech issues and product challenges. And with the whole team aligned, motivated and devoted to customer traction, we made it to an $11 million Series B.

Ultimately, not everything is harder in a recession. Some things get easier. Indeed, some of the world's biggest brands are proof that downturns reward innovation. Microsoft, WhatsApp, Venmo, Instagram and Uber lived out their formative years during recessions.

In the end, market slumps remove distractions, magnifying problems begging for immediate solutions. Smart companies can and do adapt — focusing ruthlessly on product-market fit, finding funds, scooping up critical talent and building a battle-hardened culture. This will be a test, but for founders who persevere, history is on your side.



3 Tricks the Cofounder of Netflix Uses to Make Hard Decisions Easier

Marc Randolph knows entrepreneurs often face what feel like impossible or unknowable choices. Here are three methods he uses to cut through the noise, and find the best path forward.

by **Marc Randolph**, *Co-founder and first CEO of Netflix*

Everyone makes decisions. But entrepreneurs have an especially challenging time of it because so often we must make decisions based on incomplete, inconclusive, and often contradictory data.

In my four-decade career as an entrepreneur, I have learned a few things about how to make those decisions, including the most important thing of all: Just make a decision. It may sound trite, but it's also just plain true. When so much feels like it's on the line, it's easy to become paralyzed, unable to choose which direction to take. But even a wrong decision is better than no decision because at the very least, by implementing a wrong decision you'll learn a little more about the problem you're trying to solve, making it easier to know which way to go next time.

That's why, whenever I'm forced to make difficult decisions, I rely upon a few tricks that usually make the process easier.

Here are three of my favorites.

1. Knock the flagpole down.
In 1970, in the wake of the Kent State shootings, a group of students marched into their local McDonald's demanding that the store's flag be lowered to half-staff. The store complied. Shortly afterward, the company's then-chairman, Ray Kroc, was offended and demanded that the manager once again raise the flag. He did. Upon seeing that, the students threatened to burn the restaurant to the ground unless the flag was again lowered. With things spiraling out of control, the store manager called Fred Turner, then the president of McDonald's. Turner thought for a moment and, as the story goes, he said, "Tell you what you do. The next delivery truck that arrives, have him back into the flagpole and knock it down."

Rather than obsessing about which of several bad outcomes is preferable, sometimes it's worth turning your creativity toward how to make your problem disappear altogether.

Most often I've used this approach to solve personnel problems. Once, when Netflix was only a few years old, I learned that one of our key directors was leaving the company. While dealing with her loss was manageable, deciding which of her two equally competent managers should take her place was going to be a no-win decision. Both had different but equally valuable skills. Both were ambitious and made no secret of their desire to move into the director position. But worst of all, both made it clear they wouldn't work for the other one. My solution? I simply reorganized the company in a way that let me promote both.

I'm sure they each thought it was skill and experience that led to their promotions, but what was really happening was me knocking the flagpole down.

And if that doesn't work …

2. Decide if your decision is a one-way door or a two-way door.
According to Amazon founder Jeff Bezos, there are two types of decisions: One-way door decisions require stepping through a door that then slams and locks behind you, and two-way door decisions allow you to step through, look around, and if you don't like what you see, simply step back.

Decisions affecting customer financial data, confidential personal information, and healthcare records are classic one-way doors. With the costs of an error so high, it's appropriate that great diligence goes into a decision to move forward.

But even for the most highly regulated and high-stakes businesses, the great majority of decisions do not have long-term consequences. There is no need to subject your pri-cing, your feature set, your marketing, or your sales process to the same degree of diligence that you apply to your drug-testing regimen.

At Netflix, we stepped through thousands of two-way doors. We learned that success was correlated with how many things we were able to try and that the number of things we could try was correlated with how quickly, cheaply, and easily we could try them. That in turn led to the growing realization that we didn't need to get things right the first time.

As we cut more and more corners and did things faster and faster, our tests got sloppy; we had typos, bad links, and we crashed the site. But we learned that none of it made a difference because getting something out quickly—that we could fix later! — was more important than doing a much smaller number of higher-quality, error-free experiments.

There are certainly aspects of your business that are existential risks, and you must get those right. But the skill isn't preventing yourself from making mistakes; the skill is learning how to recognize the very small percent of decisions that actually need deeper consideration.

Without developing the ability to discern the difference between one-way door and two-way door decisions, your default will be to treat every decision as a one-way-door decision, greatly slowing down the rate of innovation.

And if asking if it's a one-way or two-way door decision doesn't make things easier …

3. Accept that there is no good answer.
We all want to make "good" decisions, but I've found that many problems just don't have perfect solutions. Your current approach might be good for customers and good for margins but bad for employees. You could fix that with a second approach that's good for employees and customers — but now it's bad for margins. A third approach might be good for margins and employees, but now it's bad for customers! And around it goes. One of the most important things you can do is to recognize when you are in a decision-making loop with no exit because it frees you to break the logjam with an imperfect solution.

Finally, if you're trying to decide which of these decision-making techniques to use, keep in mind that you must find the techniques that work for you. You need to experiment. During my career, I've had to make tens of thousands of decisions — so I've had the chance to try out dozens of different approaches and learn for myself which ones work the best for me.

And if you are still stuck? There is always the Magic 8 Ball. That thing never fails.

Entrepreneur INSIGHTS

Thank You!

We hope the insights in this package have sparked the inspiration you needed to make the leap to start your own business. And while these stories are a good jumping off point for aspiring entrepreneurs, there's so much more to discover before diving in.

Get expert advice about everything from how to market your business to how to be an effective leader, by visiting us at **www.entrepreneur.com/starting-a-business**.

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